Babri Masjid, and after arriving in Pakistan began providing financial as well as logistical support to Lashkar. Criminals still based in India made important contributions too; connecting indigenous militants to one another and to Lashkar, while also funding and directing attacks themselves. Before exploring the nature of Lashkar's support to the expanding Indian jihadi movement, it is important to discuss briefly how it took shape during the early 2000s.

Two former SIMI activists, Mohammad Sadiq Israr Sheikh and Riyaz Ismail Shahbandri [a.k.a. Riyaz Bhatkal], went on to lead the Indian Mujahideen. Together they make a useful lodestar for navigating the growth of that network. Sheikh had been drawn to SIMI in the wake of the riots that accompanied the Babri Masjid's destruction in 1992, but by 2001 had grown frustrated with its inactivity and left the organization. A family member introduced him to Aftab Ansari, a ganglord who served time in prison during the mid-to-late 1990s alongside Pakistani militants.[94] Ansari connected Sheikh to Asif Khan, another well-established figure in Indian organized crime, who arranged for him to train with Lashkar.[95] Shahbandri also knew Asif Khan, from whom he sought funding for terrorist operations in India.

Shahbandri and Sheikh appear to have been working on separate tracks and though they knew one another through SIMI, it was their shared connection to Asif Khan that helped bring them together.[96] After Khan was killed in a shootout with police in December 2001, his brother Amir Khan set up an Indian jihadi outfit named the Asif Raza Commando Force. The following month, motorcycle-borne militants, operating under its banner, fired at policemen outside of the US Government's information center near the American consulate in Calcutta. Six policemen were killed and another fourteen injured.[97] Aftab Ansari was the alleged mastermind. The attackers were reportedly linked to his gang and to HuJI. Given the overlapping networks in India at the time, it is possible they shared ties to Lashkar as well.[98]

Amir allegedly began providing money to Shahbandri to send operatives to Pakistan for terrorist training and directed Sheikh, who returned to India in late 2002, to begin recruiting cadres for training there as well.[99] Once back in India, these men quickly became involved in launching bomb attacks.[100] However, Shahbandri and Sheikh were not the only two men